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Page 5-D

Enthusiasm Showing In Miner Baseball Coach



FUNNY-LOOKING FUNGO BAT—New UTEP baseball coach Larry McFarlin, right, dumps a pile of clay and dirt on the pitcher's mound at the UTEP campus while one of his hurlers, K. C. Nix, prepares to dig in with his shovel. McFarlin plans on playing

several non-conference games on the field which includes new dugouts. All Western Athletic Conference games will be played at Dudley Field.

—(Times staff photo by John Costello)

LARRY McFARLIN is no different than any other new coach taking over a sour sports program. His enthusiasm is bubbling and his expectations are high that UTEP's baseball program can and will be turned into a winner.

Matter-of-fact, McFarlin has gone so far as to predict that the Miners will make the Western Athletic Conference playoffs for the first time this season although he warns, "You can't turn it over in one year. It takes time and time is hopefully what we have."

What McFarlin found when he replaced retired Andy Cohen this past summer as a group of athletes starving for recognition and eager to work their tails off during the fall, a period of time when they were previously left to do as they pleased.

"People will be surprised at the quality of the players," McFarlin said Wednesday prior to one of his daily workouts leading up to the season opener Feb. 22 against New Mexico Highlands. "I think we can compete in the WAC. These kids have a super attitude and they want to win. My biggest problem was discipline, but after two weeks, the kids accepted me. We have a good chance for the division playoffs."

THE DEPARTURE of perennial national powers Arizona and Arizona State from UTEP's conference schedule has created much of the optimism McFarlin shares with his players.

With the Wildcats and Sun Devils moving into the Pac-10, UTEP is left in the WAC's South Division with only New Mexico and new league member San Diego State to contend with. And, only one of the three teams will be left at home during postseason competition.

"I wouldn't say that San Diego State has the same caliber of program that the Arizona schools have as far as numbers is concerned," McFarlin said, "but the Aztecs always have a good, sound baseball program. They're not going to be easy."

One of McFarlin's first priorities when hired was to convert a bumpy practice field on campus into a respectable diamond which could be used for non-conference games. Soliciting help from his players, McFarlin jumped atop a tractor and personally leveled off the infield and planted winter grass. The field had been damaged so much by intramural



Mark Leibson
Times sports writer

play that Cohen had to move his practices off campus last year.

McFARLIN WAS also responsible for building dugouts down the first and third-base lines and installing a batting cage so that UTEP's pitching machines could be removed from mothballs.

"I'm really excited about this year," said senior outfielder Bill Roberts. "Coach McFarlin has all the guys real excited and everybody wants to go out a winner. We really feel we'll have a super year."

McFarland beefed up his non-conference schedule by adding four-game series at home against Big Eight power Oklahoma and Missouri Valley Conference members Bradley and Wichita State.

"We're playing 57 games this year and hopefully, we can work up to a 75-game season," McFarlin explained. "I would like to get the Arizona schools back on our schedule and also some Southwest Conference schools. If you want to be something, you have to play the best."

McFarlin's intentions are good. As he mentioned, though, only time will tell whether UTEP's losing baseball tradition can turn over a new leaf.

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